FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

At a time when the Cold War is history and the world is infested with nuclear weapons, a land grab of a large neighbouring country was considered inconceivable. But that is exactly what happened when the inscrutable and implacable president of Russia chose to launch a vicious attack on Ukraine, a country of 44 million people with a democratically elected government. Although Russia vastly outguns its neighbour to the west of the Don, Ukraine is proving to be no pushover. Instead of rolling over and waiting to die, as Putin perhaps expected, Ukrainians are showing incredible fortitude, resilience and pluck, a touch of the old Cossack combat-readiness. They are the new indomitable Gauls, on the opposite side of Europe. Putin, meanwhile, is filled with revanchist visions that would place him in line with the czars of imperial Russia. In spite of the chilling resemblance his invasion bore to the annexation of Austria by Nazi Germany in 1938, which was a precursor to World War II, Putin ironically claimed that the prime objective for his attack was the 'de-Nazification' of Ukraine.

The irony deepens when you consider the other man in the picture: the baby-faced Volodymyr Zelensky, a native Russian-speaking Jew who has lost ancestors to the Holocaust. A former comic actor, he once starred in a show where he played a commoner who rose to be Ukraine's president and then reprised that in real life. Imagine a scenario where his screenwriter-wife Olena Zelenska wished to create a script around a pair of starkly contrasting personalities. She couldn't have asked for anything better than to have Putin set off against her husband—the 44-year-old Zelensky is affable, disarming, always threatening to break into a smile, and wears his high office lightly. A classic populist, his ratings had been sliding alarmingly of late. But as February 2022 wound to a nervy close, the world had found a new hero in him. History placed Zelensky at the centre of the 21st century's biggest geopolitical crisis, and he didn't dodge the draft. He stood his ground against an advancing Russian phalanx, exhorted his fellow citizens to fight the good fight, and refused an American offer to save his skin. By the time he video-addressed the European Parliament on March 1, from an undisclosed location and clad in a rust-coloured tee, he had already become a figure who had his visage embossed on T-shirts.



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Europe, in fact, is the heart of the dispute. Putin's original question was valid enough: should NATO, that Cold War mechanism, not only still exist but be allowed to expand, as it unremittingly has since the disintegration of the Soviet Union? It consisted of 16 members at the end of the Cold War, but today boasts a strength of 30. Unsurprisingly, the expansion was eastward—the new members all being former constituents or satellites of the Soviet Union. Putin cannot be blamed for feeling that hostile missiles now surround his country, and Ukraine's declared desire to join the alliance was a red rag to an already raging bull. While Putin was amassing his troops around Ukraine, the response of Europe was initially anaemic and disunited. America was going with its playbook of sanctions. After the invasion, the world, led by Anglo-America, turned up the heat on Russia; even Germany stirred out of its post-war pacifism, joining France in spending two per cent of its GDP on defence. Eventually, a strong united front emerged. But none of this deterred Putin. He continued his brutal assault, and even had nuclear submarines prowling the Barents Sea. To deter NATO members who may have dared to intervene, he warned of "consequences greater than you have ever faced in history". The maverick president of Belarus, Alexander Lukashenko, a Russian stooge, even spoke of a Third World War. We call it 'Russian Roulette'—a lethal game of chance in which there may be no winner.

India, too, finds itself staring at what looks like a no-win situation. It finds itself navigating a changing world order with no geopolitical or moral compass to aid it. The dilemmas are many-pronged. Russia is our oldest and stablest ally—some 80 per cent of our defence hardware is still of Russian make, and the relationship has survived even our increasing proximity to the US. How do we deal with Moscow's global ostracisation? And what do we make of the deepening Sino-Russian axis, especially if we throw Pakistan into the mix? (Imran Khan was physically in Moscow when the invasion began.) A former Indian ambassador to Russia pointedly brings it home, saying, "Imagine India's reaction if Nepal entered into a military alliance with China including having missiles directed at us. Would we sit back and watch?" Besides, American foreign policy is known to be fickle. No wonder India abstained from voting on resolutions in the U.N. condemning Russia although it put out an explanatory note that was critical of Russia. Now, if American foreign policy is consumed by the Ukraine crisis, getting more Eurocentric in focus, it would ill-serve the Indian cause. New Delhi would rather have the world's attention riveted on the containment of China than on a re-energised Europe. Strangely, one basic axiom of diplomacy has been miscalculated by both sides: Divide Your Enemy. Europe and America are more united and Russia has been pushed into the arms of China while the brave Ukrainians are more nationalistic than ever.

Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa maps out the global and local trajectories of this world-historical event in our cover story this week. He focuses on how India must be guided solely by its long-term strategic objectives and not be shilled into choosing between fluctuating shades of grey. Executive Editor M.G. Arun and Deputy Editor Shwweta Punj evaluate the economic consequences for India. Crude prices will eventually threaten to breach $125 per barrel—and Budget 2022 calculations were predicated on a $75 price range. Throw in food and commodity price spikes, and the shadow threatens to be a long one. And India Today TV Senior Executive Editor Gaurav Sawant reports from ground zero, where we hope the story will be soon abridged. Wars are easier to start than to end. There is no telling when this war will end, especially when it depends on the whims of one man—Putin. In our interconnected world, this affects everyone in some way, just like the coronavirus. The sooner both end, the better for all of us.



(Aroon Purie)